FREE BONUS · MICROSOFT COPILOT AT WORK

Copilot Prompt Cards

The most useful prompts from the book, one page per app. Replace the words in the *gray boxes* with your own details, then check what comes back before you use it.

The four-part prompt formula

1 Goal

What do you want? Start with a verb: draft, summarize, compare, list.

2 Context

Who is it for, and why? What do they already know?

3 Source

Which file, email, meeting or notes should Copilot work from?

4 Expectations

Length, format and tone: "five bullets", "under 150 words", "friendly".

EXAMPLE

Draft a short email to *customer* confirming the new delivery date of *date*. They were unhappy about the delay, so keep it warm and apologize once. Use the order details in /*order email*. Under 120 words, with a clear next step.

Where to type each prompt

Word	The Copilot pane in an open document, or the drafting box on a blank page.
Excel	Select a cell in your table (formatted as a table, one header row), then open Copilot.
PowerPoint	A blank presentation or your template for new decks; select the slide first for changes.
Outlook	The email you have open for summaries and replies; Copilot chat in Outlook for your inbox and calendar.
Teams	The Copilot pane during a meeting, the recap afterwards, or Copilot at the top of a chat.
Copilot Chat	The Copilot app, or Copilot Chat in Teams. Attach the file when Copilot can't reach it.

Before you use any answer

- Check every number, date and name against the source.
- Open the numbered references for anything important.
- Read every promise in a draft before it leaves your hands.
- Work information goes into your work Copilot only, never a personal account.
- Your plan decides what Copilot can reach. Prompts that use your email, meetings or chats need the paid work license; with other plans, attach or paste the material instead.

PROMPT CARDS

Word

Open the document first and use the Copilot pane, or the drafting box on a blank page. For prompts with /[file], type a forward slash and pick the file. Prompts that rewrite text work on whatever you've selected.

DRAFT FROM SCRATCH

Write a one-page *type of document* for *audience* about *topic*. The goal is to *goal*. Use a *friendly / formal* tone and end with a clear next step.

DRAFT FROM YOUR NOTES

Turn the notes above into a one-page memo with headings for Background, Proposal, Cost and Next steps. Keep my numbers exactly as written.

DRAFT FROM A REFERENCE FILE

Draft a proposal for *customer* using the structure and tone of */ past proposal*. Update it for *what's different this time*.

REWRITE AND EDIT

Rewrite this paragraph to be half as long. Keep every number, date and name exactly the same.

SUMMARIZE

Summarize this document in five bullet points for *audience*. Put deadlines and rules first.

ASK QUESTIONS

According to this document, *question*? Quote the exact sentence and give the section. If it doesn't say, tell me.

STRUCTURE AND FORMAT

Add a table of contents and give every section the same structure: purpose, rules as a numbered list, who to ask.

CHECK BEFORE SENDING

Review this document for unclear sentences, and suggest a clearer version of each.

MULTI-STEP EDITS

Update this document: 1) make headings consistent, 2) add a summary at the top, 3) add a comment wherever a date looks outdated, 4) list what you changed. Don't change any numbers.

LETTERS AND NOTICES

Write a letter to customers announcing a price change on *products*, effective *date*. Explain the reason in one sentence, thank them, and say who to contact with questions.

POLICIES AND PROCEDURES

Draft a one-page policy on *topic* for a small business, with sections for Purpose, Who it applies to, The rules, Exceptions and Who to ask.

REPORTS

Draft a monthly report for *audience* with sections for Highlights, Numbers, Problems, and Next month. Use these notes: *notes*.

PROMPT CARDS

Excel

Select a cell in your table before you open Copilot. Data formatted as a table, with one clear header row and calculation set to Automatic, gets the most accurate results. Check at least one number from every answer.

UNDERSTAND YOUR DATA

Describe this table: what each column contains, how many rows there are, and any columns with blanks or inconsistent values.

ASK QUESTIONS

What were total *amounts* for each *category* in *period*? Show a small table sorted from highest to lowest.

FORMULA COLUMNS

Add a column called *name* that calculates *calculation* from *column* and *column*. Explain the formula step by step.

UNDERSTAND FORMULAS

Explain the formula in cell *cell* in plain language, step by step.

HIGHLIGHT, SORT, FILTER

Highlight the *number* rows with the highest *column* in bold.

CHARTS

Create a column chart of total *measure* by *category*, sorted largest to smallest, with data labels.

PIVOTTABLES

Create a PivotTable showing the sum of *measure* with *field* in rows and *field* in columns, on a new sheet.

CLEAN UP DATA

Standardize the *column* column so the same values are spelled the same way. List the changes before you make them.

DEEPER ANALYSIS

Use Python to forecast monthly *measure* for the next three months from this table. Put the result and a chart on a new sheet and explain how confident I should be.

MULTI-STEP EDITS

Build a simple dashboard sheet: three key totals at the top, a chart by month, and a top-five table by *field*. Tell me which formulas you used.

REVIEW CHANGES

What changes have you made to this workbook today? List each cell or range and what changed.

LOOKUPS AND COMBINING TABLES

Add a column to the *table 1* table that looks up *value* from the *table 2* table, matching on *key column*. Explain the formula and what happens when there's no match.

PROMPT CARDS

PowerPoint

For new decks, start from a blank presentation (or your company template) and open Copilot. For changes, select the slide first. Every number on a slide needs checking against its source before you present.

CREATE A DECK

Create a *number*-slide presentation for *audience* about *topic*. Goal: *what they should decide or do*. Include a title slide and a final next-steps slide. Four short bullets per slide at most.

ADD AND CHANGE SLIDES

Add a slide after this one titled *title* summarizing the *section* section of /*file*, with no more than four bullets.

TIGHTEN TEXT

Cut every slide to four bullets of no more than ten words each. Don't change any numbers.

SUMMARIZE A DECK

Summarize this presentation in five bullets.

SPEAKER NOTES

Write speaker notes for every slide as three short talking points. About one minute per slide.

IMAGES AND DESIGN

Add an image to this slide showing *subject* in a *style* style.

MULTI-STEP EDITS

Clean up this deck: same layout on every content slide, four short bullets per slide, pricing before Next Steps, speaker notes on every slide. List any slide you weren't sure about.

CHECK BEFORE PRESENTING

Check this deck for inconsistent numbers between slides, and list any differences.

TRAINING AND ONBOARDING DECKS

Create a 10-slide onboarding presentation for new *role*s from /*handbook*: welcome, who's who, first week, key rules, tools, and where to get help.

SALES AND CUSTOMER DECKS

Create a seven-slide pitch for *customer* using /*proposal*: their goals, our offer, pricing, delivery, why us, next steps.

CREATE A DECK

Create a presentation from /*Word file*. One section per heading, short bullets, and speaker notes on every slide.

ADD AND CHANGE SLIDES

Add an agenda slide after the title slide, based on the sections in this deck.

PROMPT CARDS

Outlook

Summary and reply prompts work on the email you have open. Inbox, calendar and organizing prompts go in Copilot chat in Outlook; the ones that act on many emails need the paid work license and always ask you to confirm.

SUMMARIZE

Summarize this thread: what's been decided, what's still open, and what's being asked of me.

DRAFT REPLIES

Reply to confirm *detail*, ask *question*, and thank them for *thing*. Under 100 words, friendly.

DRAFT NEW EMAILS

Write an email to *person* asking for *request* by *date*. Explain why it matters in one sentence.

IMPROVE YOUR DRAFT

Make my draft shorter and clearer without losing any details.

INBOX AND CALENDAR QUESTIONS

Which emails this week still need a reply from me? List the sender, date and what they need.

MEETINGS AND SCHEDULING

Schedule a *length* meeting with *people* next week about *topic*, and add a short agenda.

ORGANIZE YOUR INBOX

Create a rule that moves emails from *sender or domain* to a folder called *folder*.

CUSTOMER SERVICE REPLIES

Reply to this customer question about *topic* using our policy: *policy summary*. Friendly, clear, under 120 words.

WORKING WITH SUPPLIERS

Write an email asking *supplier* to confirm the delivery date and quantity for order *number*.

SUMMARIZE

Summarize this email in two sentences and tell me if I need to reply.

DRAFT REPLIES

Politely decline this request. Explain briefly that *reason* and offer *alternative*.

DRAFT NEW EMAILS

Write a follow-up email to *person* about *topic*, since I haven't heard back since *date*.

PROMPT CARDS

Teams and Meetings

Meeting prompts work in the Copilot pane during a meeting, or from the recap afterwards if the meeting was transcribed. Chat prompts work in Copilot at the top of a chat. Most need the paid work license.

DURING A MEETING

Summarize what's been discussed so far in five bullets.

AFTER A MEETING

List every action item from this meeting as a table: Task, Owner, Due date. Write 'Not agreed' where no date was set.

CHATS AND CHANNELS

Summarize what I've missed in this chat.

COPILOT CHAT IN TEAMS

Draft a short Teams post reminding the team about *rule or deadline*, friendly and clear.

PLANNING AND RUNNING MEETINGS

Draft an agenda for a *length*-minute meeting about *topic*: items, time for each, who leads, and the decision needed.

DURING A MEETING

What decisions have we made, and what questions are still open?

AFTER A MEETING

Draft a follow-up message to attendees with the decisions and action items.

CHATS AND CHANNELS

What were the key decisions in this chat in the last 7 days?

COPILOT CHAT IN TEAMS

Write a short message congratulating *team* on *achievement*, mentioning *specific detail*.

PLANNING AND RUNNING MEETINGS

Write a short pre-meeting message to attendees with the agenda, what to read beforehand, and what decisions we'll make.

DURING A MEETING

What did *name* say about *topic*?

AFTER A MEETING

Summarize this meeting for someone who missed it, in under 150 words.

PROMPT CARDS

Copilot Chat

Use these in the Copilot app (or Copilot Chat in Teams). Sections marked paid license rely on Copilot reaching into your own email, meetings, chats and files; with other plans, attach or paste the material instead.

CATCH UP (PAID LICENSE)

What did I miss while I was out from *date* to *date*? Group by project and put anything that needs my response first.

WORK WITH FILES

Summarize /*file* in five bullets for *audience*.

FIND THINGS (PAID LICENSE)

Find the latest version of the *document* and tell me who last edited it.

DRAFT AND BRAINSTORM

Give me ten ideas for *goal*, each in one sentence, then pick the three most practical.

RESEARCH AND EXPLAIN

Explain *term or concept* in plain language with one example from *industry*.

PAGES AND SHARING

Turn this answer into a short page with headings that I can share with the team.

CHECK AND IMPROVE

Which parts of your last answer are you least sure about, and why?

SCHEDULE IT (PAID LICENSE)

Every Monday at 7:30: list customer emails from last week that still need my reply, and my customer meetings this week.

LEARN AND UPSKILL

Teach me *Excel skill, such as PivotTables* in five short lessons, with one practice task after each.

DECISIONS AND PLANNING

Help me decide between *option A* and *option B*. Ask me three questions first, then compare them on cost, risk and effort.

CATCH UP (PAID LICENSE)

Summarize everything about *customer or project* from the last *period*, across email, chats, meetings and files.

WORK WITH FILES

Compare /*file 1* and /*file 2* in a table on *criteria*, then recommend one.

PROMPT CARDS

Prompts by Role

These prompts combine apps for common jobs. Many assume the paid work license where they mention your email or meetings; adapt them by attaching the files yourself.

MANAGERS

Draft agenda points for a one-to-one with *team member* based on our recent emails and meetings.

SALES

Prepare me for my call with *customer*: recent emails, open issues, past orders I can see, and three questions to ask.

HR

Draft an inclusive job ad for a *role*, avoiding jargon and unnecessary requirements.

FINANCE

Summarize this month's results from the *table* table: totals, biggest changes vs last month, and three sentences of commentary.

ADMIN ASSISTANTS

Find a time next week when *people* are all free for a *length* meeting, and draft the invitation.

PROJECT MANAGERS

Create a project plan for *project* with phases, tasks, owners and dates from these notes: *notes*.

CUSTOMER SERVICE

Write three versions of a reply to this complaint: one short, one detailed, one that offers *remedy*.

OPERATIONS

Turn these notes into a daily opening checklist for the warehouse: *notes*.

MARKETING

Write three social media posts announcing *event or offer*: one for each of *channels*, within each channel's typical length.

BUSINESS OWNERS

Summarize this month across email, meetings and files I can see: wins, problems, and decisions I need to make.

MANAGERS

Write constructive feedback for *team member* about *situation*: what went well, what to change, and one specific suggestion.

SALES

Draft a follow-up email after my meeting with *customer*, summarizing what we agreed and the next step.

PROMPT CARDS

Follow-ups that fix any answer

One short follow-up usually turns a nearly-right answer into a usable one. Type it in the same conversation.

WHEN THE ANSWER IS…	TRY THIS FOLLOW-UP
Too long	"Half the length." · "Three bullets only."
Too vague	"Expand point 2 with an example."
The wrong tone	"Warmer." · "More formal." · "More direct; remove the apologies."
The wrong format	"As a table." · "As numbered steps." · "As an email."
For the wrong reader	"Rewrite for a customer." · "Rewrite for a new employee."
Missing something	"You left out *topic*. Add it in the right place."
Possibly wrong	"Where did that come from? Quote the source."
Wrong on a fact	"The date is *date*, not *date*. Fix it everywhere."
Too generic	"Use the details in /*file* instead of general advice."
Hard to act on	"End with the three next steps, who does each, and by when."
Overconfident	"What would change your conclusion?" · "What are the risks?"
Not quite you	"Use shorter sentences and plain words. No exclamation marks."

MORE FROM THE AUTHOR

Enjoyed these cards?

A short, honest review on Amazon is the single most useful thing you can do for an independent book. It helps other readers find the right guide, and every review is read.

See every book by Reid Weston: Reid Weston on Amazon

Updates to these cards and to the book are listed at https://rw-books.github.io/copilot-at-work-bonus/